CHINEKWU PAULIN ENWONWU (OWOH)

Department of Economics
Northeastern University
360 Huntington Avenue
Boston, MA 02115

Phone: +1 (617) 297-1177
Email: owoh.c@northeastern.edu
LinkedIn: linkedin.com/in/chinekwuowoh
Website: chinekwu-enwonwu.github.io

Placement Director: Dr. Bilge Erten
b.erten@northeastern.edu
+1 (617) 373-2886

Education

Northeastern University, Boston, MA
Ph.D., Economics — 2022–2027 (expected)

University of Hamburg, Hamburg, Germany
M.Sc., Economics — 2015–2017

University of Ghana, Legon, Ghana
B.A., Economics and Political Science — 2009–2013

Fields

Primary: Development Economics
Secondary: Labor Economics, Public Economics

References

Dr. Mindy Marks
Associate Professor of Economics
Northeastern University
m.marks@northeastern.edu

Dr. Bilge Erten
Associate Professor of Economics and International Affairs
Northeastern University
b.erten@northeastern.edu

Dr. Matthew B. Ross
Associate Professor of Public Policy and Economics
Northeastern University
ma.ross@northeastern.edu

Job Market Paper

Digital Financial Inclusion and Infant Health: Evidence from Mobile Money Expansion in Kenya

Can digital financial services improve infant health where households face severe liquidity constraints? I study the rapid expansion of mobile money agents in Kenya. Combining administrative data on agent locations with retrospective birth histories, I compare siblings born to the same mother under different levels of local mobile money access, and complement this with an instrumental-variables strategy based on proximity to early adoption hubs. Greater mobile money access substantially reduces infant mortality: the average within-county expansion in agent density lowers infant mortality by 0.43 percentage points, or 11 percent of the sample mean. Effects are largest where initial access is low. The mechanism is better maternal care: mothers shift from home to institutional delivery and begin antenatal care earlier, while free inputs such as vaccinations and maternal labor supply are unchanged. Digital financial inclusion can improve early-life health by relaxing short-run financial barriers to health care.

Working Papers

Implicit Taxation and Labor Supply: Evidence from Public Housing Rent Reforms

Public housing rent is set at 30 percent of household income, a 30 percent tax on additional earnings. The Quality Housing and Work Responsibility Act of 1998 let residents pay a flat rent instead, removing this tax for those earning enough to switch. Using the 1996 SIPP linked to HUD Fair Market Rents, I study whether this option increased employment. I first show that the reform's reach was narrow: based on household income, 18.8 percent of residents could gain from flat rent, almost all in households with a second earner. I then estimate employment effects by comparing high earners across low- and high-rent metropolitan areas and by using each household's potential saving from flat rent.

Deferred Compensation and On-the-Job Performance: Evidence from Police Productivity

How do pension reforms affect on-the-job productivity in the public sector? I exploit staggered changes in state pension rules in the United States and measure police productivity using arrest data from the FBI's Uniform Crime Reports. Using a stacked difference-in-differences design, I find little change in overall arrest activity in the short run, but meaningful differences across enforcement margins: violent crime arrests remain largely unchanged, while drug and property crime arrests and arrests per capita decline. Pension reforms appear to reduce policing intensity and shift effort away from more discretionary enforcement, while leaving core public safety functions intact. Changes in deferred compensation can shape not only labor supply but also on-the-job performance where effort is hard to monitor.

Pre-Ph.D. Research

Owoh, Chinekwu. "The Effect of Migration on the Education of Children Left Behind in Their Home Country." *Baze African Journal of Management and Social Sciences* 1 (2018).

Teaching

Northeastern University, Boston, MA, Recitation Instructor (Undergraduate) 2024–2025
Principles of Microeconomics

Northeastern University, Boston, MA, Teaching Assistant 2022–present
Principles of Microeconomics; Principles of Macroeconomics; Microeconomic Theory; Statistics for Economists; Behavioral Economics; Law and Economics; Women's Labor and the Economy

Baze University, Abuja, Nigeria, Instructor (Undergraduate) 2018–2022
Introduction to Macroeconomics; Mathematics for Economists II; Introduction to Statistics; Urban and Regional Economics; Introductory Labour Economics; History and Structure of the Nigerian Economy
Supervised an undergraduate final-year research project

Research Positions

Research Assistant for Dr. Matthew B. Ross, Northeastern University, Boston, MA 2023–2024
Project: *Driving Change: Evaluating Connecticut's Collaborative Approach to Reducing Racial Disparities in Policing*
Cleaned and harmonized data and Stata code; produced descriptive statistics

Research Affiliate, Native Insight, Nigeria 2018–present

Academic Service

Organizer, Academic Writing Workshop Series, Baze University 2019–2022
Departmental Course Advisor, Baze University 2018–2022

Grants

Returning Experts Grant (€31,932), German Agency for International Cooperation (GIZ) 2018–2021

Skills & Personal

Software: Stata, R, Python, LaTeX
Languages: Igbo (native), English (advanced), German (basic)
Citizenship: Nigeria; U.S. Permanent Resident